

Credibility & Counterarguments

Study Guide - Arguments & Sources

1. Learning goal

Judge whether a source is well positioned to support a specific claim and analyze how an argument acknowledges and responds to opposing views.

2. What this skill means

Credibility is claim-specific. A source can be knowledgeable about one issue and weak on another. Counterarguments show what an opposing side says; a strong response answers the actual concern with relevant evidence or reasoning rather than ignoring or misrepresenting it.

3. Do not confuse it with

Do not assume "official" or "expert" automatically means credible for every claim. Also distinguish a real rebuttal from simply repeating the original position.

4. How GED-style questions may ask it

Questions may ask: "Which source is most credible for this claim?", "Why is this source relevant?", "How does the writer respond to the objection?", or "Which response most strengthens the argument?"

5. Repeatable method

- Identify the exact claim the source is being used to support.
- Ask what knowledge or access would be needed to support that claim.
- Check whether the source has that expertise, data, or direct responsibility.
- For counterarguments, state the objection fairly.
- Check whether the response answers the objection with evidence, concession, limitation, or reasoning.

6. Worked example

A composting proposal cites the sanitation department for estimates of household food waste and a composting facility for processing capacity. A restaurant owner objects that collection bins will smell; the proposal responds with odor-complaint data from a sealed-bin pilot.

Question: Why are the cited sources useful?

Reasoning: Each source is matched to a claim it is positioned to know: waste volume, processing capacity, and odor performance.

Best answer: Because the sources have direct responsibility or data relevant to the specific claims they support.

7. Common traps

- Choosing a famous source whose expertise does not match the claim.
- Treating one person's experience as proof of a citywide pattern.
- Calling something a rebuttal when it never answers the opponent's actual concern.

8. Diagnostic help

- If you chose a source because of status alone, ask what specific information that source actually has.
- If a response changes the subject, it has not answered the counterargument.
- If the writer admits part of an objection but limits its importance with evidence, that can be a strong concession-and-response strategy.

9. Quick check

A transit agency provides ridership counts; a local café owner predicts the route will increase citywide tax revenue.

Which source is better positioned to support a claim about ridership?

Check yourself: The transit agency, because it directly collects ridership data; the café owner may offer local experience but not systemwide counts.